

Go green today



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Editor

“One of the biggest mistakes people make is to think that going green is something only the rich can afford to do”

In this space, over the last two months I’ve challenged you to improve yourself. Although a lot of you might feel that this month’s challenge is tough, personally, I think it’s the easiest one of all thus far.

Digit’s coverage of the whole “green” issue in the past has usually focussed on what social organisations, corporates and governments are doing to save the planet. We’ve stuck to that in the past because we thought it was the only way to include “technology” in everything we wrote about. Digit is committed to improving our lives – usually through technology. However, we’ll stray every once in a while, if required, to get an important enough message across.

April 22, 2010, is the 40th anniversary of Earth Day, and no matter who you are – old or young, male or female, geek or amateur – the planet is something we should all care about. It is, after all, the only one we’ve got. That’s a message we felt we just couldn’t ignore. This issue is our attempt to convince you to give a damn for the Earth we all live on, and we’re not going to be talking about corrupt governments, helpless NGOs, technologies that no one can afford, or sit back and shake a fist in anger at the supposedly evil corporations who are killing us with pollution in order to make a quick buck. That would be too easy. Instead, we’re asking you to take a good look at yourself, and see how you can improve your own life.

I see a lot of similarities with our indifference towards the environment and littering. In India, we’re used to making a mess around us. Why? Because everyone litters, what difference would it make if we didn’t? However, those of us who have lived or travelled abroad know that we litterbug Indians magically transform into obedient, civic conscious citizens when in another country, which proves that all we really need is for someone to set an example, and others will follow.

It’s possibly an education problem as well. For example, one of the biggest mistakes people make is to think that going green is something only the rich can afford to do. This misconception arises from the fact that greener devices are usually more expensive. However, if you look at it logically, you’ll soon realise that those same devices work out cheaper in the long run. Yet, bafflingly, in the land of savings accounts and frugal living, where almost everyone seems to start saving for

retirement whilst still in their 20s, too many of us still prefer to buy cheaper, but more power-hungry incandescent bulbs, instead of investing in low-power, longer-lasting CFLs.

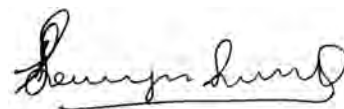
Most of us from the Digit community live in cities, and are avid technology users. What we need to understand about this simple statement is that we’re also contributing a lot more than the average Indian to global warming and other “brown” effects. Something as simple as walking or cycling short distances instead of using motorised transport, or just charging your cell phone using solar energy could work wonders – not just for the environment, but for your own health as well.

Whether you’re saving on power or fuel, or nurturing and planting trees, going green will benefit you in very measurable ways. You’ll save money, live healthier, and even be happier. Most of what you’ll read in this issue will help you do just that, but there’s more.

It’s not just about changing what you do, but also what you buy. All of us know that every PC, laptop or gadget we buy is made from silicon, plastics and metals that are mined, purified and manufactured using processes that can scarcely be called environment-friendly. So should we all stop using technology altogether, and go back to the good old snail mail days? No, of course not, but we can choose to find out more about the companies who we buy products from. Even if it means spending a little more, I’d rather buy a product made by a company who follows strict norms, and even goes that extra mile to try and offset the damage they’re doing to the environment.

We’ll play our part and keep feeding you with regular articles to help you identify newer ways to go green. However, we also want you to tell us what you’re doing, no matter how small you think your actions are. We’ve even started a Facebook page for this very reason.

Go to www.facebook.com/ithinkgreen, and either get some interesting ideas or give the Digit community more food for thought. Of course, you can also use our forum (thinkdigit.com/forum) to discuss topics such as these with Team Digit members as well. 


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